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To: [Smith, Andy E. \(DHHS\)](#)
Cc: [May, Alfred](#)
Subject: CP - work update, 02/12/2007-02/23/2007
Date: Monday, February 26, 2007 5:04:43 PM

On my Plate

ED & Asthma epi/surveillance paper
Drinking Water Content Workgroup / Data Resources Sub-team
Arsenic in water, data evaluation and mapping
Birth outcomes and ambient air, multi-state project
Cancer Registry geocoding support
CLPP - surveillance definitions support/discussions
Other indicators for ambient air, birthweight - **Syndromic Surveillance for CO**
IPHis AVR toolkit
CO Surveillance Database
Other MeCDC: Birth defects cluster inquiry

Time Allocation

Task	Target - revised	Reality
ED & asthma epi/surveillance paper	10%	<5%
Drinking Water Content Workgroup	20%	5%
Arsenic in water, data evaluation and mapping	20%	35%
Birth outcomes and ambient air, multi-state project	20%	<5%
Cancer Registry geocoding support	10%	25%
Other indicators for ambient air, birthweight, CO	<5%	20%
IPHis AVR toolkit	<5%	0%
CLPP support	10%	10%
EOHP - hiring, staff support, IT thorns	<5%	<5%
CO Surveillance Database	5%	<5%
Weekly update	<5%	<5%

Activities/developments

ED & asthma epi/surveillance paper
o nothing new here

Still true: I'll need to declare a week (or two) to work on this, to the exclusion of almost everything else.

Drinking Water Content Workgroup / Data Resources Sub-team

- o Water CWG
- joined Indicator sub-team for Arsenic

Data Evaluation sub-team is awaiting other States' comments on Public Water data survey tool.

Arsenic in water, data evaluation and mapping

- o Lisa has been feeding me sample data reports from StarLIMS
- o explored HETL data for glitches and other potential issues: i.e., missing fields, ambiguous entries, etc.
- o inquired of MEGIS regarding ArcGIS tools for spatial interpolation

Data cleaning is going to be a headache, but we're used to that. Response from John Nims about availability of pre-StarLIMS data was scary ('it's in a file cabinet, on paper'), but probably misleading. Lisa is very close to generating the essential data and attributes essential for analysis.

ArcGIS has a tool for spatial interpolation, by way of an extension, but I learned that I'm the only person to ever ask for it! MEGIS said they can install a 30-day demo for me. I said I'd wait until my data is prepped and ready for mapping.

Birth outcomes and ambient air, multi-state project

- o no new developments

Cancer Registry geocoding support

- o wrote up an extensive brain dump of strategies and issues related to geocoding
- o evaluated address cleaning/conversion software
- o attended EPHT-MCR meeting

I put considerable effort into a lengthy summary regarding potential methods for geocoding, and issues related to census tract assignment and tract-level analysis. A number of my suggestions (e.g., land parcel data and commercial ZIP+4 data) have never been brought up by MEGIS. This was cc'd to Molly, and to Dan Walters. Apparently this memo was of sufficient density to dissuade any response.

I also evaluated the commercial address cleaning tool which CDC has implemented as part of their Lead data cleaning wizard. I recommended to Castine that they license this ASAP and apply it to Registry addresses before MEGIS does a final geocoding run. Of key interest: the tool's database includes E911 address conversions (from e.g. rural routes). In principle, that information could be spotty, but I found a zipcode-level tabulation of the # of address conversions and, happily, every zipcode in Maine was >0.

There was also a late request for input on Portland-area geocoding to aid the follow-up of the North Deering cluster/environmental inquiry. I did some overlays and checked data availability. I believe this is a good training opportunity for MCR to do the geocoding themselves - but of course there needs to be some QC applied.

CLPP surveillance definition and data support

- o no new developments, for my part

Discussions and consultations with Lisa P, per usual.

Other indicators for ambient air, birthweight

- o full day of meetings regarding Syndromic Surveillance pilot project, and use of CDC EARS software tool

This soaked up some time. But I'm favorably impressed with Amy Robbins' and Don Ward's handling of this project, and by the reasonable, no-nonsense, it-is-what-it-is approach of the CDC staff supporting the analysis Tool. On the downside, it may be a while before some major hospitals in Maine contribute a data stream.

Interestingly, it seems that others are trying out SS for CO poisoning, for instance in Boston and Vermont. It's not clear whether they include very non-specific symptoms as part of the definition, or only mentions of "CO"/"CO2". I'm going to follow up with contacts in the aforementioned places.

My initial take stands however, that the Tool's utility for us will be to compare data coming from the hospital ED logs to the reports we get through the formal CO surveillance system.

IPHS AVR toolkit

- o nothin'

EOHP - hiring, staff support, IT thorns

- o no developments regarding Lead Epidemiologist candidates
- o I applied for a USM job

I snail-mailed a CV and cover letter to Doug last Wednesday, and emailed him the same later. I haven't heard back.

CO Surveillance Database

- o no developments

Other MeCDC

- o birth defects cluster inquiry response

Meeting and correspondence from Kathy Decker. Meeting included Ellie M.

There is a practice/nurse query regarding birth defects in Vassalboro or surrounding area. As would be expected, the number of unvalidated defects in Childlink are either similar to statewide rates, or marginally of interest (i.e., excess), depending on the time/place cutpoints. At this point in time, the numbers are too small to follow up on. Kathy found excellent materials and protocol for birth defects cluster investigation from California. I directed her to MCR, for letter templates and protocol for "heightened surveillance" in this kind of situation. This inquiry could fizzle, or it could become more interesting - in a year's time.

I don't understand the current limbo status of Birth Defects right now, but supposedly there is a

new hire coming on imminently?